Jeff Cox was an editor on one of America's first organic gardening magazines, and now writes on cooking and gardening from his home in Sonoma, California.

broccoli soup

SERVES 4–6 **PREP** 10 MINS **COOK** 40 MINS **FREEZE** UP TO 3 MONTHS
AT THE END OF STEP 3

1 tbsp lemon juice
1½lb (675g) broccoli florets
3 tbsp butter
2–3 celery ribs, finely chopped
2 leeks (white parts only), chopped
4 tbsp plain flour
1½ quarts (1½ liters) hot chicken stock
salt and pepper
½ cup heavy cream
2 tbsp snipped chives, to serve

1 Bring a large pot of salted water to a boil and add ½ tbsp of the lemon juice. Add half the florets and cook for 3 minutes, or until just tender. Remove to a colander and run cold water over them to stop the cooking. Let them drain and set aside.

2 In a large saucepan, melt the butter over medium-low heat. Add the celery and leeks and cook, stirring, for 5–7 minutes or until the vegetables are tender. Add the flour and stir it in thoroughly, then whisk in the stock until the flour is entirely absorbed. Turn the heat to high and bring to a vigorous boil, then reduce the heat to low and simmer for 5 minutes.

3 Chop the uncooked broccoli into small pieces and add to the soup. Simmer for 15 minutes, or until very tender. Process in a blender until almost smooth—you want to retain a slightly grainy texture.

4 Return the purée to the saucepan, season to taste with salt and pepper and the rest of the lemon juice, then add the cream and the reserved broccoli. Reheat and serve, sprinkled with chives.